8

WHERE TO BEGIN

THE FIRST 100 WORDS

KEY POINTS

- Four tasks of a feature lead
- Nutgrafs and billboard paragraphs
- Leads that succeed
- Leads to avoid
- Establishing "bookends"

If the opening paragraphs of a feature story don't grab readers' interest, the content of the article—regardless of its importance—may remain forever unread. An article's introduction has four jobs to accomplish: attract attention, introduce the topic, set the tone and establish the point of view. To add to the writer's challenge, the best leads occupy limited space. The opening sentence of a newspaper feature may contain as few as 12 to 15 words; the opening sentence of a magazine feature lead may double or even triple that word count, depending on the audience.

Here are two examples from very different publications that are geared to highly specialized audiences. As you read them, ask yourself whether they accomplish the four tasks of effective leads.

- Of the 600 or so students enrolled each year at New York Theological Seminary (NYTS), only 15 are residential—but they are *extremely* residential. Each year 15 men from prisons throughout the state of New York are selected for the seminary's master of professional studies class

Feature and Magazine Writing: Action, Angle and Anecdotes, Third Edition.
David E. Sumner and Holly G. Miller.
© 2013 David E. Sumner and Holly G. Miller. Published 2013 by John Wiley & Sons, Inc.

that meets inside the walls of Sing Sing Correctional Facility in the town of Ossining.[1]

- "Ten years ago, Steve Jobs was alive, Bob Hope was alive, Johnny Cash was alive. Now we're outta jobs, outta hope and outta cash." I heard that from a TSA agent in New York the other day, as he eyed me for explosives. We laughed, but there was a poignant edge.[2]

Both lead paragraphs introduce serious topics. The first is about educating prisoners; the second is a commentary about the stalled economy. Both writers use a humorous tone to lighten their heavy topics. Both quickly establish the point of view—story one uses the third person; story two uses the first person. Both opening sentences contain fewer than 25 words. Neither writer has to "dumb down" her vocabulary because both publications serve readers who are well educated and knowledgeable about the topics at hand. The first example, taken from *In Trust* magazine, is aimed at governing boards of seminaries. The second example, published on the opinion page of *The Wall Street Journal*, is aimed at a readership that is savvy on economic and political issues. Although college students might not find either lead particularly engaging, both examples work well for their intended audiences.

COMING TO TERMS WITH LEADS

Organizing a feature story is a lot like solving a complex jigsaw puzzle. By the time you sit down in front of your computer screen, you've gathered an assortment of bits and pieces of information, many of them disjointed, that you now must assemble into a seamless "picture" for your readers. Where do you begin? Which note or quote do you pull from your stash of research and use to create that all-important paragraph that will lead into the content? Which piece do you set aside to serve as the perfect wrap-up to your article?

Many journalists agree that the most difficult part of writing articles is creating attractive leads and satisfying endings. One of our colleagues underscores the importance of strong beginnings and appropriate conclusions with this comparison. He says that feature articles, like airplanes, are most vulnerable to crash during takeoff and landing. His point: An article can contain great information, but, if the opening paragraph (the "takeoff") doesn't grab and hold readers' interest, they may turn the page and move

on. The ending of an article, like the landing of an airplane, should be smooth rather than abrupt, fast-paced rather than prolonged. Like pilots who know their destinations before taking off, writers should identify their endings before beginning their articles. Otherwise they risk getting lost, taking detours or wandering in circles as they try to decide how and when to stop.

Writers use three terms—often interchangeably—to describe the opening paragraphs of feature articles. Each term has an appropriate meaning. "Lead" is a fitting description because an effective first paragraph *leads* readers into the story. "Hook" is an accurate term because a strong opening paragraph *hooks* readers' attention and nudges them to continue. "Introduction" is a logical label because writers use the initial paragraphs to *introduce* their topics and establish the tone and point of view of their articles. If a writer is going to tell a story from his own point of view, as in a personal essay, the word "I" is likely to appear somewhere in the lead. If the tone of the article is going to be conversational rather than academic, that attitude is going to be evident from the first sentence.

Writers often labor for hours over their introductory paragraphs. They fine-tune, add, delete and exchange words until they are satisfied. They scrutinize their notes in search of effective hooks. They experiment with anecdotes, provocative quotations and surprising facts that may have surfaced during the research phase. Some writers tell us that they can't move forward with their articles until they have the leads precisely as they want them. Other writers prefer to forge ahead, complete their rough drafts and then return to their opening paragraphs to do the fine-tuning—the adding, deleting and exchanging of words. Whichever process works best for you is the process you should follow.

Taken together, leads and endings serve as the bookends of articles. They hold everything in place. Once you have created the lead paragraph and the closing paragraph, you have established your boundaries. The next challenge is to arrange the remaining content in logical order. This is not easy, of course, but the lead paragraph should give you a direction and the closing paragraph should give you a destination.

BEYOND THE SUMMARY LEAD

Unlike reporters who cover breaking news events and get to the point quickly, feature writers have the luxury of setting up their articles with

well-crafted and engaging opening paragraphs. This doesn't mean that they never use the familiar, no-frills summary lead that answers basic questions—who, what, where, when, why and how. It simply means that they have the flexibility to experiment with more engaging approaches.

Summary leads have taken a lot of criticism in recent years. They were the predictable way of getting into a story for so long that a backlash was inevitable. "Boring!" claim their critics. Maybe so, but what summary leads lack in creativity they make up for in information. Here are two examples of summary leads that appeared in articles related to the skyrocketing price of gasoline during the summer of 2008 and the spring of 2012.

The first lead introduced a news story published in *Rolling Stone*: "Four-dollar-a-gallon gas prices are eating away at the summer-concert business, with top festivals and tours taking unexpected box-office hits over the past few months."[3] This 29-word opening sentence contains, in a nutshell, the essence of the article. It answers the six basic questions. Who? Gasoline. What? Is eating into profits. Where? On the concert circuit. When? This summer. How? By reducing attendance. Why? Because prices have soared to $4 per gallon. Depending on their level of interest, readers could stop reading after the lead sentence or could continue to learn the details of those rock artists who played to capacity crowds and those performers who canceled their bookings.

A similar summary lead, published four years later, worked equally well to introduce a news feature also linked to rising fuel costs. *USA Today* tied escalating fuel costs with the calendar in this way: "Don't expect relief from high gasoline prices by flying to your spring break vacation. Airfares already are up this year, and every sign is they'll remain high for summer vacation, too."[4] Like the *Rolling Stone* lead, this one is aimed squarely at the publication's audience (*USA Today* is popular reading material for airline passengers). It answers many of the basic questions. Who? You (understood). What? Shouldn't expect relief from high gas prices. Where? On flights. When? Spring break. Why? Prices are soaring (again). The lead succeeds because it summarizes in two sentences the gist of the article. Subsequent paragraphs flesh out the story's premise with statistics, quotations from experts and anecdotes about people frustrated or angry about the high cost of airline tickets. Readers who are not interested in the supporting information can turn the page after the lead paragraph.

Some feature writers, bogged down by writer's block, create summary leads as a way to get a few words on their computer screens and achieve some momentum. After their articles have begun to take shape, they often

go back to their summary statements and top them off with more creative leads. However, they don't delete the summary paragraphs. Instead, they keep them as their second or third paragraphs, often called billboard paragraphs or "nutgrafs." Such paragraphs, which we refer to throughout this book, tell readers what the story is about, in a nutshell. Many editors expect every article to contain a nutgraf or billboard paragraph. The logical placement is immediately after the lead.

LEADS THAT SUCCEED

In our opinion, few rules are unbendable when it comes to feature writing. A gifted writer can make almost anything work. For that reason, we encourage students to experiment with a variety of lead paragraphs and then decide which ones they like best. Factors to consider include:

- *The publication.* Many newspapers and magazines prefer short articles limited to a page that don't require much time to read. In these cases the editors are likely to depend on the old workhorse, the summary lead.
- *The topic.* How-to articles usually get to the point quickly because readers are anxious to access the advice and care little about creative introductions. Often profiles and articles that probe complex issues lend themselves to more leisurely treatment.
- *The audience.* Demographic data such as age, profession and education levels sometimes influence readers' preferences regarding writing styles. Persons who read for entertainment may enjoy descriptive opening paragraphs; persons who read for information may prefer a straightforward approach.

Every journalism textbook has its own vocabulary for classifying and describing leads. Except for the well-recognized anecdote lead, there are no universally recognized "types" of leads. We conducted an informal survey of about 60 articles in a dozen popular consumer magazines. About 80 percent of them mentioned a person in the lead—via either an anecdote, quote, narrative or scenario of some kind. In his book *Magazine Writing That Sells*, Don McKinney explained these four basic ways to begin a story:

- Start by telling a story.
- Start by letting someone else talk.
- Start by thrusting us into the action.
- Start by telling us what you're going to tell us.[5]

From the many options available, we've chosen to describe six leads that work well regardless of the publication, topic or audience. We accompany each description with one or two examples to serve as models.

Anecdote lead

Anecdotes are little stories about people that occurred in a specific place at a specific time. Often called the "chocolate chips of feature writing," they are perhaps the most frequently used leads in feature and magazine stories. Readers love these little stories that illustrate rather than dictate the important facts of a feature. In an article titled "Why China's Weight-Loss Industry Is Gaining," note the specific details in the opening anecdote that illustrate the larger theme of China's weight-loss industry:

> As an only child growing up in Shanghai, Simon Wang was plied with dumplings, ice cream and Kentucky Fried Chicken by his parents and grandparents. After tipping the scales at 220 pounds, the 26-year-old decided to join Weight Watchers last month.
>
> "I will get a heart attack more easily than a normal person," says Wang, who is 5 feet 9 inches tall and wants to shed 55 pounds. "When I get older I will have lots of problems, maybe high blood pressure and a lot of other illnesses."[6]

In writing about the desegregation of a Southern high school, journalist Josh Peter captured the story's essence with an insightful opening anecdote. The series of articles, published in *The Times-Picayune* (New Orleans), was a finalist in the "diversity" category of the annual "Best Newspaper Writing" competition sponsored by the American Society of Newspaper Editors. Notice how the opening three sentence fragments set the scene for the action that unfolds in the locker room.

> Friday night. Homecoming. An hour before kickoff.
>
> In the darkened locker room, hushed but for the sound of cleats scraping the concrete floor, one voice pierced the quiet.

"Juicy!"

Jarid Caesar called over teammate Anthony "Juicy" Trosclair, captain of the Riverside Academy football team, to hear the song he listens to before each game.

There they sat, side by side on a wooden locker-room bench: Trosclair, the white defensive lineman, and Caesar, the black running back, each pressing a headphone against one ear and nodding to the beat.

It was a moment once unthinkable at this small private school in Reserve.[7]

Scenario lead

By accurately recreating a place, the scenario lead allows readers to "see" the backdrop against which the story unfolds. The key to creating a successful scenario lead is to avoid too much description. Don't include every detail; be selective; use a light hand in sketching the environment. Let the reader's imagination take over from there and fill in the gaps.

In the following *Vogue* lead, the author invites her readers to join her—or at least to eavesdrop—as she and her guest enjoy a leisurely chat over a glass of wine. The guest is actress Meryl Streep; the project is a profile article that will occupy eight pages (plus cover) in the magazine; the newspeg is the release of *The Iron Lady*, the film about former British prime minister Margaret Thatcher. (Streep went on to win the Academy Award for her performance.) Before the author gets into the heart of the interview, she creates a sense of place. Notice her sparse but precise use of details. The conversation doesn't merely occur in the afternoon, but at 4:20; the site isn't just a restaurant, but the restaurant located on the mezzanine of Union Station. The use of present tense gives a feeling of immediacy.

"Oooh, they have oysters," says Meryl Streep, perusing the menu with intent. "Would you like to get some oysters? Wouldn't oysters be great to eat right now?" It's 4:20 in the afternoon. We are the only people in the restaurant on the mezzanine at Union Station, Washington, D.C. I pass, but Streep says, "I think I'll have some oysters. And a glass of Chardonnay."[8]

Shock lead

Lead paragraphs that contain a shock element are likely to grab and hold readers' attention at least for a little while. They succeed if, in the course of

doing research, the writer uncovers a truly surprising bit of information. Chances are the information that surprised the writer also will surprise the readers. Sometimes, as in the case of this first example, the lead sentence is relatively short. The humorous tone, established at the outset, continued throughout the article, as the author gave an overview of new electronic gadgets available to consumers. "Shortly before Valentine's Day, a study was released claiming that 47 percent of men in Britain would give up sex in return for a big-screen plasma television. As with all matters relating to technology, numbers are key: precisely how long were these men prepared to go without sex? And how large a screen?"[9]

Sometimes a writer combines categories of leads, as Wendy Brenner did for her introduction to a feature article for *The Oxford American*. The story was a finalist in a National Magazine Awards competition. Part shock and part anecdote, the opening paragraph is humorous and memorable. Notice the understated, casual tone.

> One day in 1971 in Wilmington, N.C., 14-year-old Dean Ripa was at home performing surgery on a cottonmouth snake, and it bit him. This was unfortunate for a couple of reasons. He knew enough about snakes to know he would probably not die, but he did need a ride to the hospital, which meant his parents were going to find out about the 50 snakes he was keeping in their spare room: rattlesnakes, the water moccasins he'd caught in local swamps, even several cobras he had purchased via mail-order—he had a king cobra years before he had his driver's license.[10]

Blind lead

A blind lead raises readers' curiosity by omitting a key piece of information. The omission causes readers to continue reading until they satisfy their curiosity. The lead is "blind" because it doesn't immediately identify by name the person or persons who are the subjects of the article. That important fact remains a mystery until a later sentence or paragraph clarifies it. In the following example, from a feature article about a former rock musician who dramatically changed his lifestyle and traded careers, readers don't learn the identity of the interviewee until the third sentence.

> Business majors can party. They can get wasted, wake up the next morning, hit 18 holes, and still make afternoon classes. But few have the expertise of

Duff McKagan, bassist for Guns N' Roses and Velvet Revolver, and student at the Albers School of Business and Economics at Seattle University.[11]

Direct or indirect quote lead

A quotation can serve as an effective lead if a speaker has said something noteworthy that sums up the article's main idea. A variation on the quotation lead is the indirect quotation lead. This works well if you want to capture the essence of what someone said but you don't want to use the speaker's exact words. Here are examples of both options. First, a direct quote from a fitness expert succeeds because his comment would likely surprise readers who hold different opinions. Thus it combines the shock/surprise and direct quote categories. "'Unless you're training for a marathon, bike race, or triathlon,' says Rodolpho Reyes, 'Cardio is an inefficient waste of a guy's time.'"[12]

For a profile article about one of the world's best-selling romance novelists, a magazine writer opened with an indirect quotation and ended the paragraph with a direct quote. This lead contains elements of the scenario, indirect quote and direct quote leads.

> The trouble with writing at home, says author Janette Oke over the din of her dishwasher, is the ever-present lure of housework. It's always there, tugging her away from her computer, beckoning her from her research and causing her to leave her characters fending for themselves, mid-plot, somewhere out on the Canadian prairie. "Once a housewife, always a housewife," she adds with a shrug that lets you know she wouldn't have it any other way, thank you.[13]

Direct-address lead

The direct-address lead invites the reader to participate in the story. How? The writer speaks directly to the reader by using the word "you" in the opening paragraph. The resulting lead is much like a conversation between writer and reader. Often the narrator is offering friendly advice to the reader. The weakness of direct address leads is that the writer can appear condescending and fail to respect the intelligence of most readers. Another weakness is that the writer can assume that the described scenario is common or familiar to readers when it is not. That's why it's so important to know the characteristics of the readers for whom you are writing.